

Project Report: Cybercrime Awareness – UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a common type of cybercrime in India where scammers trick users into transferring money using digital payment apps. This type of fraud mainly targets beginners, students, elderly people, and small business owners who may not fully understand how online payment systems work.

In a typical case, the scammer contacts the victim through a phone call, SMS, or social media while pretending to be a bank official, customer, or service provider. They create urgency by offering a refund, reward, or by claiming there is an issue with the victim's account. The victim is then asked to click on a link, scan a QR code, or approve a "collect request." Many users think they are receiving money, but in reality, they are authorizing a payment. Once the request is approved and the UPI PIN is entered, money is instantly transferred to the scammer's account, and recovery becomes very difficult.

The consequences of such fraud include financial loss, mental stress, and loss of trust in digital platforms. This highlights the importance of digital awareness and safe online practices.

To stay safe online, users should follow some important precautions. They must use strong and unique passwords and enable two-factor authentication for extra security. It is important not to click on unknown links or share personal details like OTPs and passwords. Users should always verify websites before entering sensitive information and keep their devices updated.

For financial safety, users should never approve unknown UPI collect requests and should not scan QR codes to receive money.

It is also important to double-check the receiver's name and UPI ID before making any payment and avoid using public Wi-Fi for transactions.

In case of any cyber fraud, users should immediately report it on the **National Cyber Crime Portal** (<https://www.cybercrime.gov.in>) or call the **helpline number 1930** for quick assistance.